

Vertigo

[> Chair's Report](#) [> Section News](#) [> Notices](#) [> Coming Trips, Courses, Events](#) [> Trip Reports](#) [> Section Contacts](#) [> Our Club On A Page](#)

No 813 January 2018



NEW ZEALAND
ALPINE CLUB

Wellington Section Monthly Bulletin

www.facebook.com/nzacwellington Twitter [@NZACWellington](https://twitter.com/NZACWellington)

Exiting the crux, directly above the notch, at about 1,350m. Mitre Peak - Peter Laurenson

Chair's Report

January 2018

Hope you have all had an interesting and enjoyable month and that you were able to spend as much of it climbing, tramping and or generally being outdoors. If you weren't you are probably an exception. Based on the endless stream of traffic pouring into Mt Cook, Milford and other popular destinations, it seemed like the rest of the world had been vacated. I was one of them and it's a fair bet that if you are keen on climbing of one sort or another, that you were too and, like me, you are now back home.

Depending on where you go, climbing can get you away from the campervans and SUVs with their obligatory boat trailers. You might think that Mitre Peak would provide at least a bit of that wilderness and isolation experience but you would be wrong. Overlooking Milford Sound, the constant buzz of helicopters, planes, cruise ships and tour boats from dawn to dusk made for a very different kind of wilderness experience. If you want to get a feel for the intensity of tourism, it's worth the climb. It's also worth the climb for the awesome view - but don't expect much serenity - 'so much serenity'.

In other news, and if you have been reading our accounts and wondering why we have had a decline in our Banff income, the Paramount here in Wellington has shut down. In doing so the directors kept some of the income from the ticket sales. We now need to find a new venue so if you know any venues that can accommodate up to 400 people, are not extortionate and available, please get in touch with the committee. We will also change our ticketing system to ensure any thieving type cinema owners can't get their hands on your hard earned cash.

The other thing I did this month was re-discover Alexander Von Humbolt. Know who he was? Humbolt Falls, Humbolt Mountains. Humbolt was one of, if not the first, scientists to identify human activity as a cause of climate change - only he did this in the late 1700s. One of Humbolt's most significant contributions was the interconnectedness of nature and all its elements from atoms to elephants. He developed the concept of Cosmos and was instrumental in the establishment and advancement of a wide range of disciplines, including ecology, geology, biogeography, meteorology and oceanography. Look him up.

"By felling the trees which cover the tops and sides of mountains, men in all climates seem to bring upon future generations two calamities at once; want of fuel and a scarcity of water" Baron Alexander von Humboldt (1769 - 1859).

If you have any comments on what you like or don't like send an email to wellington@alpineclub.org.nz or tweet us [@NZACWellington](https://twitter.com/NZACWellington).

Simon

Simon Williamson
Chair: NZAC Wellington

From the Editor

Welcome back to Vertigo - the first edition for 2018. And happy new year! I hope, like me, you've managed to enjoy some of the good weather over the Christmas break. I'm looking forward to receiving your trip reports asap. Just type up a report of between half a page to three pages as a Word document, email it to me at occasionalclimber@gmail.com with one to six jpeg images and I'll format it for Vertigo.

Don't forget the page quicklinks at the base of each page - they let you go straight to the page you want rather than having to scroll back and forth all the time.

Peter

Section News

February Section night

Our gathering in February will be on the 21st from 6pm at Hangdogs in lower Hutt, where climbing and pizza consumption can occur.

Section nights beyond February

Wed 28th March, we're back at the Third Eye, to hear from John Phillips about his climb of Acongagua - the highest peak in South America.

Wed 25th April, Rohan Light will talk to us about risk management and decision making in the field.

Wed 30th May, Marcus Thomas will present his spectacular Cave book.

Wed 27th June - TBA, any ideas please let me know.

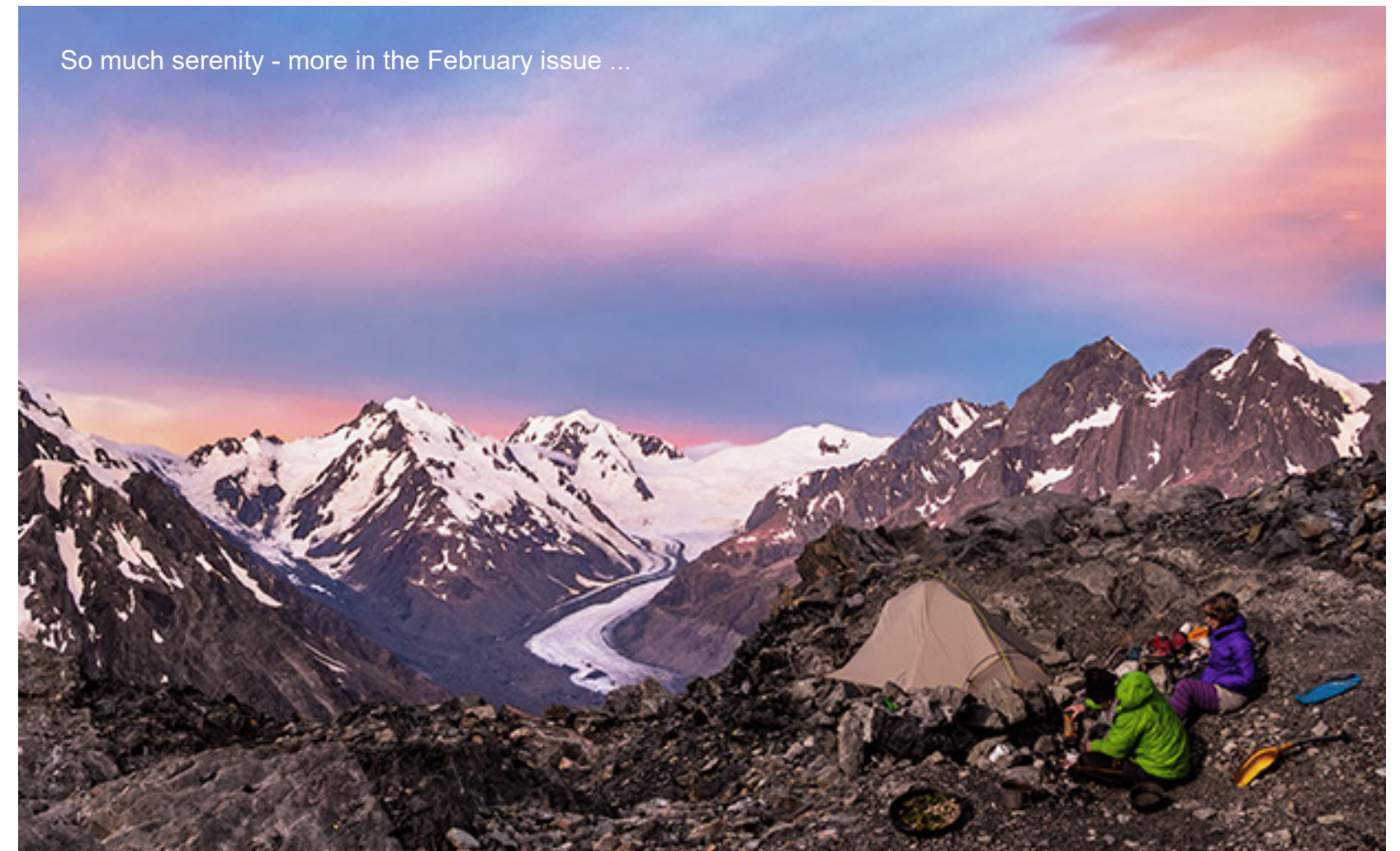
Wed 25th July, Ross Cullen will take us through three years of Norwegian scrambling and climbing.

Wed 29th August, it's the annual Wellington Section Photo competition judging evening.

Wed 26th September, Penny Webster will take us through her quest to climb all of New Zealand's 3,000m peaks.

Wed 28th November, Nina Sawicki will take us on a journey to Kanchenjunga base camp in Nepal.

So much serenity - more in the February issue ...



Section News

Gear Hire

Don't forget the Section has gear for hire: avalanche transceivers, ice axes, shovels, stakes, hammers, helmets, crampons, probes, PLBs, ice hammers (entry level).

To hire gear please fill in the form [here](#).

Each item costs \$5 per week with the exception of PLBs – PLBs are free but require a deposit of \$50 refundable on return.

A little bit of advance notice would be appreciated as gear often needs to be retrieved from the gear store in Lower Hutt. Gear collections and drop-offs are usually available in the city during the working day or at section night.

Accommodation on Mt Ruapehu

Our snowcraft courses for the past few years have been run out of the Manawatu Tramping and Skiing Club lodge on Whakapapa. We're always made to feel welcome and the lodge is well situated a short walk from the top of the Bruce Road. Membership to the club is extremely reasonable - \$35 per year or \$50 for a family membership. Members stay at the lodge for \$36 a night including food. If you're looking for somewhere to base yourself for your winter pursuits or rock-climbing over the summer months go to www.mtsc.org.nz/joining.php to find out more about joining the club.

Marion Minifie

In her obituary in the Timaru Herald, 29 April 1969 it is stated that 'Mrs Minifie was a keen trumper and climber and was one of the first women to climb Malte Brun in 1900'. As far as I can find, the first ascent of Malte Brun by a woman was by Freda Du Faur in January 1911, so my grandmother's must have been later. I would be grateful for any further information.

David Minifie - david@minifie.co.nz

Heading to Mt Cupola, Nelson Lakes

Notices

Aspiring Huts – Colin Todd, Esquilant Bivvy, French Ridge and Aspiring Huts

Hut users, please note you can only pay hut fees in advance via the NZAC website for the above huts. When doing so, please ensure you take your emailed receipt with you as proof for the wardens. The Department of Conservation has been getting a lot of people saying they will pay NZAC later, but we tend to only see advance payments online. The likelihood now will be that without a receipt to prove pre-payment, the DoC warden will require payment at the time no matter what they are told. The user would need to prove a double-payment later before they could claim a refund.

FMC Discount – Interislander Travel

The 15% discount off easy-change and saver-change fares have been extended. The discount that ran for travel up to 30 Nov 2017 has been extended to restart from 1 Feb 2108 to 30 Nov 2018. An online discount code is viewable when you log into the Club website and you need to show your FMC discount card at the check-in: <https://alpineclub.org.nz/company/interislander/>.

International Snow Science Workshop preliminary programme [here](#)

CCUSA - Camp Counsellors USA

CCUSA is the leader in the American Summer Camp industry and the only Kiwi Company to have a 100% placement record for 28 years, the most affordable program in New Zealand, offering the most benefits, including the highest earning potential at camp. Apply [here](#).

NZ Alpine Journals to Give Away

A fifty plus year member has a complete collection of Alpine Club journals from 1953 to the present day free to a good home but postage would need to be paid from Wellington. Contact Catherine Ferguson 04 9708438 or catherineferguson99@gmail.com.

Information on NZ alpine hut systems requested

Ang Rita Sherpa is from Khumbu and a graduate from Lincoln University in Parks and Recreation in 1986. He hopes to build a series of mountain shelters on the Three Passes trekking route to reduce danger there. He seeks technical and financial support thepartnersnepal.org.

Mountain Festival in Kyrgyzstan

Climbers from all over the world are invited to celebrate the 90th anniversary of the first ascent of Lenin Peak, 7134m. Celebration activities include ascent of Lenin peak, trekking, guided walks, etc. More information and to book [here](#).

NZAC Taranaki Section Climbing Meet

Friday evening 23th-25th February, Stratford Mountain Club's Manganui Lodge, \$60 per person for Accommodation and food, Saturday breakfast/dinner and Sunday breakfast provided, Limited to 30 people. Contact Phill Davies ascent.phill@gmail.com to book or if you have questions.

UIAA ice climbing season

The provisional calendar for the 2018 UIAA Ice Climbing season is now in place. Read [more](#).

ICopro canyoning course: 6-13 April

More information and registration [here](#).

Coming Trips, Courses, Events

All our planned South Island trips come with the added bonus that rental vehicle costs for Wellington Section members are covered by the Section.

If you're uncertain about the skill level required with any of the trips, would like to register your interest or to find out more, email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

Also, please contact us if you're keen to run a trip yourself – the Committee can help with advertising and logistics.

When	Where
3 - 6 February 2018	The National Climbing Camp, Tukino, see details at right
9 - 12 March 2018	Trip to Paynes Ford led by Eric Duggan. The section will pay for transport from Nelson to Takaka and return

NZAC National Summer Climbing Camp - Tukino

The Tukino Alpine Sports Club is host to the NZAC National Summer Climbing Camp next February 3-6 at Tukino ski field on Mt Ruapehu. The camp is an opportunity for climbers to get together to climb mountains, rocks, socialise, explore and enjoy the great outdoors. It is also a great opportunity for young people and families to get out and try trad climbing. There are a number of crags well set up with easy access to the top to build anchors and low grade routes (8-14) with plenty of good pro placements. There are also now plenty of easy bolted routes, as well as the more challenging graded routes, for those wanting to experience alpine rock cragging!

Cost: Catered accommodation (NZAC members): \$37.50 per night for Adults and \$18.75 for under 18. You must reserve your accommodation for the camp as well as completing the registration form. We will assist with carpooling where possible and shared cost of transport for carpooling is expected.

Tukino Lodge capacity is 40 people per night so please get your registrations in quick.

Register [here](#)



Trip Reports

As Simon pondered the viability of down climbing another steep section soaring above, it occurred to me that we were going to run out of time. We were at 1,430m and the summit was a further 250m above. Yes, we'd climbed the crux alright, but the highly exposed, relentlessly steep terrain above the crux still wasn't conducive to fast travel.

We had to be back down at sea level by 5pm for our Roscos Milford Kayaks water taxi pickup and, between us and the water line was difficult terrain most of the way. Adding to the challenge was a lack of water and we knew that rushing a tough, exposed route in a dehydrated state was a recipe for trouble.

"I think we're going to run out of time guys" I said. "Maybe, let's discuss it and make a call" replied Caro. Simon stepped down off the next little vertical stairway and asked "What's our height?" "1,430m with 250 still to climb" I replied. "It's taken us about two and half hours to get here. Maybe another hour to the summit. Down climbing won't be much quicker than going up with this level of exposure. Say mid-day by the time we reach camp. We know we've got a four hour descent from there and we'll be tired and dehydrated. Making the 5pm pickup is doable but leaving no margin for error." We all agreed. The view from where we sat was sufficiently awesome, we already had the satisfaction of climbing the crux and our fifty plus year-old bodies wouldn't appreciate conforming to such a tight deadline. Added to this, the forecast was for a change to rain and we could already see cloud building around us. The thought of descending the steep, dense Fiordland bush beyond the treeline in the wet made me grimace. Down we went.

Above the Fiord

Words and pictures Peter Laurenson

I'd been keen to climb Mitre Peak (1,683m) for some time. Though under 1,700m, the climb begins at sea level, so it's still a significant undertaking. And the peak is just such an icon. A real postcard celebrity, photographed by nearly every international tourist who visits our South Island. The previous summer another Alpine Club friend, Mike Neely and I had come south to have a crack, but the weather was poor in Fiordland so we went up to the Annette Plateau in Aoraki National Park instead.

This time I was with two other Alpine Club friends, Simon Williamson and partner Carolyn Ellis and our luck with the weather seemed to be with us. We'd just enjoyed two magnificent days doing the Ball Pass route, followed by a rainy travel day down to Homer Hut. Now the weather had cleared again – windy on day one but calming on day two, before another front was forecast that evening – it was on.

On day one we had to be at Roscos Milford Kayaks' departure point at Deepwater Basin for 6.30am. A return trip per person is fairly pricy at \$120, but this includes a walkie talkie and on the hill comms and their team is very friendly. The first challenge, aside from enduring the hoards of sand flies, was actually getting ashore with a hefty water-laden pack. There's just a small band of slippery rock between the boat and bush. We all made it without anyone getting wet.





Anyone who’s been in Fiordland bush knows how dense it is. We had a steer from our water taxi skipper, Dion, as to where the trail actually began a little to the true left of Sinball Gully stream. Just as well because, at our drop off point, we were confronted with a wall of forest. If Trump wants to build an impenetrable wall around the US of A he should check out Fiordland – not only would he keep out uninvited aliens but also gain carbon credits.

The first five hundred or so metres is probably the toughest – relentless up, root ladder after root ladder, pack snags, constant risk of going off route. We did find later that coming down it was easier to follow the trail, but we still lost it for a while about 200 metres above the sea. At 541m we reached the first ridgetop. After that the going was a little easier up to the Footstool at 832m, where we got our first decent view of the upper section of Mitre Peak. And yes, it looked steep.

From the Footstool was a 150m steep descent to a saddle where we encountered the first of two small campsites. At the first was a pan, half filled with rain water – an unexpected bonus given the lack of water sources on Mitre Peak. A little further on, at 730m, was the second campsite where we decided to stay. Later Simon discovered a nearly dried out tarn nearby, where he scrounged a couple of extra murky litres of water which we thoroughly boiled for tea. Water is an issue. In such tough terrain you need plenty, but you have to carry it, which makes pack lugging more arduous.

We also carried a 60m rope, harnesses and a few slings. Depending on who you talk to Mitre Peak is touted as a straight forward rock scramble through to a truly epic undertaking. We took the gear just in case, but that only added more weight to our packs. As it turned out for us, the truth was somewhere in between. If we’d had more time I’m certain we would have free climbed the entire route and my background is not a rock climber. But unless you’re an Alex Honnold kind of guy, the yawning exposure can’t be ignored. Climbing up or down the upper sections of Mitre Peak is a mind game to some degree. I was acutely conscious much of the time that a single misplaced step or careless hand hold would end in a freefall to the fiord.

After establishing our camp we rested in the sun until the sand flies drove us back into action. It was too windy to contemplate going for the top that day, even though we still had enough daylight. But we did scramble up out of the bush (about 950m), past the high snow grass campsite (about 1,050m) and on along the exposed rocky ridge as far as the south eastern lip of the notch (1,300m). Though gusty, the sky was a brilliant cobalt and the views from the often knife-edged ridge were magnificent. At one point a gigantic cruise liner came in to view 1.3 vertical kms below us, appearing like a bath tub toy. Looking at it made me thirsty as I pondered our limited water supply and the unlimited beverages being consumed below me. Oh for an ice cold beer!

Simon and Caro were in their tent overnight. I was under the stars and a sand fly head-net in my bivy bag. Once the sand flies ceased their sieging of my head about 10pm I enjoyed the night sky and noticed how the wind eventually dropped away altogether.

We set off for the summit just after 6am and enjoyed the sunrise as we ascended now familiar ground up to the notch. We had decided to leave the rope and harnesses at camp and travel as light as possible. When I first reached the lip of the notch I wondered if I'd somehow gone off route again. It was a sheer drop into an uninviting void below me. But on closer inspection it became apparent that there was actually a very steep but quite reasonable trail dropping down from the lip to the narrow notch. What rose up on the other side looked somewhat more intimidating and I could see then why this section was deemed the crux. Should we have brought the rope after all?

It required some trial and error to find the safest route up out of the notch. But in the calm, dry conditions we enjoyed, there was no need for a rope, just patience and concentration, particularly for the first fifty or so metres. I must confess that Mitre Peak continued to surprise me all the way though. After the crux I'd expected that the gradient would relent more than it did. All the way to our turn around point at 1,430m exposure was ever present and steep stair cases continued to present themselves.

I would have loved to get to the top, but we were all satisfied that our retreat was the right call on the day. Will I be back for another crack? Probably not. As I get older I seem to stomach sustained exposure less and the ratio of type two to type one fun is not ideal. But if I did return I would only do so in a perfect two day weather window, in midsummer when there's plenty of daylight to work with. I would swap climbing gear for more water, then go for the top on day one, then bivy at the 730m camp. On the way back to Deepwater Basin Dion told us that only about a third of his clients reach the top. He also told us that a local had once completed the climb, including a self-paddle to and from, in nine hours. In bare feet! Recently that record has been reduce to seven hours. Madness.



A local pops in at our campsite at 730m



On our descent of the crux, above the notch
For more - occasionalclimber.co.nz

Section Contacts

Powered by volunteers

We're always thankful for volunteers and members stepping forward to help the section run smoothly. A lot goes on to keep our club going, virtually all powered by volunteers. On the back page is our "Club on a page" summary. It gives an at a glance description of all the things we do, how and why. Feel free to print a copy and pass it on to anyone who might be interested in becoming a member or volunteer. And if you'd like to learn more about how you could get involved, please email us at wellington@alpineclub.org.nz.

A warm welcome to our new Committee members Keith, Guy, Blair and Joshua; and a grateful farewell to Elisha and Sandy.

Role	Name	Contact
Chair person	Simon Williamson	021 054 7684
Secretary, gear custodian	Carolyn Ellis	021 574 287
Treasurer	Vacant	
Trip co-ordinator	Eric Duggan	021 350 161
Section nights, Vertigo, Photocomp	Peter Laurenson	021 446 725
Social media	Marie Kelly	
Club liaison	Keith Munro	
Library, Projects	Alex Waterworth	
General Committee	Matt Pemberton	
General Committee	Guy Dubuis	
General Committee	Blair Bryant	
General Committee	Joshua Mouat	
Patron	John Nankervis	



www.facebook.com/nzacwellington
Twitter @NZACWellington

Shed 6 Queens Wharf
Wellingtons Waterfront
Ph 04 4998898 Fax 04 4998896
wn@fergskayaks.co.nz
www.fergskayaks.co.nz

Open 7 Days

Largest Real Rock Indoor Rock Wall – Kayaking – Inline Skates - Retail - Rental

Alpine Club members can climb any time for \$12
Monday nights show your Alpine Club card and climb for \$10

New routes every week*

\$1000 worth of new holds in Jan/Feb 2012
New pad in "Da Cave" allowing safe aggressive bouldering

Creating happiness through better climbing

* to be precise, this is just an average but we do aim for new routes every single week.

HangDog Rock Climbing Adventures
453 Hutt Rd
Lower Hutt
(04) 589 6181
info@hangdog.co.nz

www.hangdog.co.nz

i climb .co.nz

Simond alpine equipment direct from the importer

Ocelot
\$115

MXC 820
\$230

Makalu
\$255

Caiman
\$230

i climb .co.nz



For quick access to our Section's page on the NZAC website, click or scan this QR code

WHAT WE DO

FOR MEMBERS

Facilities

- * Huts
- * Gear
- * Library
- * Discounts

Training

- * Level 1- 3 winter skills
- * Summer rock
- * Instructors

Climbing trips

- * Section
- * National
- * International

FOR MEMBERS AND WIDER PUBLIC

Publications

- * Website
- * Social media
- * Vertigo
- * Guide books

Events

- * Banff mountain film festival
- * Reel Rock
- * Photo comp

Networking

- * Section nights
- * Conferences and meetings
- * Lobbying

HOW WE DO IT

Organise, encourage, support, enable

Inform, entertain, promote

OUR RESOURCES

Volunteer time and capabilities, income from events and gear hire, national office support, sponsorship

WHY WE DO IT

Connecting & developing more climbing & mountaineering people, knowledge, skills & experience, thereby ...

... building lifelong friendships

... protecting and improving access to alpine places

... sustaining and growing climbing and mountaineering achievement

... enhancing alpine safety

... building appreciation, enjoyment and protection of alpine places